BUSINESS PLAN · PLAIN ENGLISH

Charm City Sites

A one-person website factory for Baltimore's trades. This plan explains, in everyday words, what it does, who it serves, how it earns its first $2,350, and how it all gets built.

Prepared for the operator and family

Baltimore, Maryland · September 2026

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1. What This Actually Is

Picture a small factory that lives on a laptop. Raw material goes in one end: a plumber's name and phone number. A finished, live website comes out the other end about ten minutes later. Nobody sits and types the words. Nobody drags boxes around a design screen. The machine writes the text, pours it into a ready-made design, puts the finished site live on the internet, and buzzes the operator's phone when the job is done.

The factory has four stations, and each one is boring on purpose. The clipboard is a simple spreadsheet; one row holds one plumber's name, number, and neighborhood. The writer is an artificial-intelligence program that reads each row and produces every word the site needs: the headline, the list of services, the reasons to call. The assembly line is a finished website design, built once, that accepts new words the way a cookie cutter accepts new dough. The delivery truck parks the finished site on free internet space, and the doorbell is a phone notification that says the site is live.

The operator's whole day shrinks to three moves: add a row, send the short message the machine drafts, and talk to the plumber who says yes. There is no hopping between programs and no juggling of tools, which was the founding requirement of this design. One machine runs quietly in the background while a person does the human part: greeting, listening, and closing.

2. The Problem Being Solved

Most small trade businesses in Baltimore never get a website, and the reason is rarely money. A master plumber is excellent at pipes and short on spare hours. Do-it-yourself site builders advertise ease, but they quietly eat an entire weekend and still look homemade. Full agencies do beautiful work for $1,500 to $5,000 and take weeks to deliver; a two-truck plumbing outfit cannot justify that spend. So the website stays on a wish list, sometimes for a decade.

The cost of that delay shows up at 7 p.m. on a Tuesday, when a pipe bursts in a Canton rowhome. The homeowner grabs a phone and searches for a plumber nearby. Businesses without a site do not appear in that moment, and the ones with only a bare social page look unproven. The job goes to whoever looks real. It is a silent loss; nobody sends a bill for the work that never rang.

There is a second leak. While a plumber is elbow-deep under a sink, the phone buzzes unanswered. Each missed call is a $300 to $1,500 job that simply called the next name on the list. Between the invisible business and the missed call, a hardworking operator loses more in a month than a website would ever cost. This plan attacks both leaks with two small products, described next.

3. The Two Products

Product one is the spec website. "Spec" is an old trades word for work done on speculation: the tailor makes the suit first, then offers it for sale. Here, the factory builds a complete website for a real Baltimore plumber before any money changes hands. Every site carries a big tap-to-call button, a plain list of services, a short quote form that alerts the owner's phone within a minute, a reviews section, and the details search engines read. It loads fast on a phone, because that is where every customer is.

Product two is the missed-call helper. When the owner cannot answer, an automatic text goes back to the caller within seconds: a short apology, an invitation to describe the problem, and a promise to call back. One recovered job usually pays for the setup twice over. Both products are one-time purchases, not subscriptions, which tradespeople read as a mark of honesty.

Product	What the client receives	Price
Spec website, built before payment	Mobile-first site: tap-to-call button, services list, quote form with instant alerts, reviews section, search-ready details	$500 first client, $650 second, $800 third
Missed-call helper	Automatic text-back within seconds on unanswered calls	$400 setup

Table 1: The two products and their prices

A note on honesty: there are no monthly fees in the first six weeks. The sites run on free hosting. The text service, when switched on, runs on the client's own phone account, so the client pays that bill directly and always owns it. The operator sells finished results, not rentals.

4. The Money Math

$2,350

Total collected within about six weeks

The math is deliberately small. Three websites at $500, $650, and $800 add up to $1,950. One missed-call helper at $400 brings the total to $2,350, collected within about six weeks. "Collected" means money actually in the account, not promises; each site is paid for at delivery, and the helper is paid at setup. No invoice chases, no net-30.

What	Amount	When
Website, first client	$500	Week 2 or 3
Website, second client	$650	Week 4
Missed-call helper, sold to a happy client	$400	Week 4
Website, third client	$800	Weeks 5 and 6
Total collected	$2,350	Day 45 or sooner

Table 2: The six-week collection ladder

The price climbs on purpose. The first site sells at a friend price because there is no track record yet. By the third, there are live examples and a testimonial, and $800 reads as a bargain against a $2,000 agency quote. Costs stay near zero: no inventory, no rent, no subscriptions. Every tool in the factory is free, and the only machinery is the laptop itself.

Can it actually make money? Yes, on one condition: the daily outreach actually happens. Ten short messages a day, roughly a hundred by the second week, is what turns three yeses from luck into arithmetic. The plan treats that rhythm as the real job and treats everything else as background noise.

5. Who Needs This and Why

The primary buyer is a Baltimore home-service trade owner, 35 to 60, running a phone-first business out of a truck and a home office. Plumbers come first, because the city's aging rowhomes guarantee a steady drip of emergencies: burst supply lines, ancient boilers, root-clogged drains. Most of these owners have a social page or nothing at all where a website should be, and they are politely skeptical of anyone selling "online presence" as a concept.

They buy for plain reasons. Their customers check a screen before dialing; a clean page with a real name, real services, and a big call button passes the sniff test. A finished site is an easier yes than a proposal, because there is nothing to imagine, only something to look at. And the seller is local: same weather, same potholes, someone who picks up the phone on a Saturday.

A second group appears on the state's public list of newly licensed contractors. A brand-new licensee needs everything at once and has no incumbent web person to disappoint; meeting them in their first month is worth ten cold messages a month later. The third person in the story never buys anything: the homeowner with the burst pipe, who just wants a credible name and a button to press. Every design decision in the factory serves that person's thirty-second visit.

6. How Customers Are Found

Finding buyers is unglamorous and free. The map is the phone book now: searching neighborhood by neighborhood for plumbers whose listing shows no website link produces a working lead list in an afternoon. The state's public licensing records, read in reverse date order, surface fresh contractors before competitors notice them. The city's neighborhood business directories and community boards round out the picture, and happy clients eventually hand over the best leads of all, usually with a handshake attached.

The daily rhythm matters more than the sources. Ten short messages go out each day, and each one points at a website already built for that specific business, with a 60-second phone video scrolling through it. The message is honest about what happened: "I built you a website, no strings. It's yours for $500 if you want it, live today." Quiet leads get one gentle follow-up after three days and a final note after a week, then a respectful stop. A clear no ends all contact, permanently and with good manners.

Showing finished work instead of a portfolio changes the conversation. A stranger pitching "web services" gets deleted; a neighbor handing over a live thing with the plumber's own name on it gets a reply. That difference, repeated a hundred times, is the entire growth engine of this business.

7. The Competition

Four kinds of competitor already serve this market. Do-it-yourself builders cost little in dollars and plenty in weekends, and tradespeople rarely finish the job. Agencies do excellent work at $1,500 to $5,000 over several weeks, aimed at clients who have marketing budgets. Freelance marketplaces offer $300 to $800 sites, but communication is slow, the seller is remote, and quality is a coin flip. New AI site builders produce something fast and generic, with no local person to call when the quote form breaks.

Option	Typical cost	Speed	Local human	Built for trades
DIY builders	$20 or more per month, plus a weekend	Slow	No	Partly
Agencies	$1,500 to $5,000	Weeks	Sometimes	Rarely
Freelance marketplaces	$300 to $800	Days to weeks	No	Sometimes
AI site builders	$10 to $30 per month plus upsells	Minutes	No	Generically
Charm City Sites	$500 flat, one time	Same day	Yes, in Baltimore	Yes

Table 3: How the options compare

The wedge is the spec model itself: finished-before-payment removes the leap of faith. Add same-day delivery, a flat price with no subscription, a local person who answers the phone, and the missed-call helper that none of the others bundle, and the offer stops being a comparison and starts being a category of one. Competitors are not beaten on features; they are skipped on trust.

8. Can Someone Steal This?

The honest answer, since this plan will be read aloud at a kitchen table: the idea cannot be locked up like an invention. Anyone can copy the concept of building spec websites for trades. What cannot be copied is cheaper and more durable: the months of head start, the machine itself, the relationships, and the name.

The machine is private. Every template, every automated workflow, and every script lives on the operator's own laptop under personal accounts, never published to any public repository. A copycat starts from zero while the operator is already three testimonials deep. Relationships compound the same way: a plumber who has been treated well tells other plumbers, in a city where word travels faster than advertising. The lead spreadsheet quietly grows into the real asset, a private record of which words, prices, and neighborhoods convert, knowledge no rival can buy.

Simple habits keep it that way: working files stay private, fresh accounts carry the business, templates are never sold or shared, and the brand name is used consistently from the first day so it gathers recognition. None of this requires a lawyer; all of it requires consistency. The moat is motion: being months ahead and staying in it.

9. How Setup Happens

The operator's stated constraint was "no time for manual setup," so the split of labor is blunt. The assistant builds the entire machine: the site template, the factory that turns spreadsheet rows into live websites, the three automated workflows, the demo site shown to prospects, the click-by-click account sheet, and the one-command installer that assembles everything on the new laptop.

Task	Who does it	Time
Site template, factory, automation workflows	Assistant, built and delivered ready	Zero operator hours
Four free accounts (Google, Cloudflare, messaging, Meta)	Operator, following the click-by-click sheet	About 30 minutes, once
Pasting access keys into one settings page	Operator	About 5 minutes, once

Task	Who does it	Time
Running four one-line setup commands on the MacBook	Operator	About 10 minutes, once
Answering prospect messages and calls	Operator	Ongoing; this is the actual job

Table 4: Division of labor

Nothing needs configuring by hand beyond that. Accounts are created fresh, keys are pasted once into a single settings page, and the installer handles the rest while the hardware is still in its shipping box. The first live demo site exists before the laptop arrives, so the operator can practice the pitch on something real.

Day one on the new machine is deliberately short: run the installer, watch the factory build one site from one row, then send the first ten messages. Total human setup time sits around forty-five minutes, spread across the first few days, and none of it involves writing code.

10. A Day in the Life

Morning: the operator

The day starts with the phone, not the laptop. Overnight, the factory may have finished a site or two, and the morning digest lists today's ten new touches, every due follow-up, and any replies. Ten messages go out before the coffee gets cold, each pointing at something already built. Mid-morning brings a call with a plumber who has just watched a 60-second video of a website bearing his own name; the conversation is short because the thing already exists. The afternoon holds one delivery, one testimonial request, and tomorrow's list.

Afternoon: the client

A plumber who bought in last week gets a ping on his phone: a homeowner submitted the quote form three minutes ago, while he was under a sink. That evening, a call he misses gets an instant text back, and the caller books for tomorrow. He paid once, owns the site outright, and tells his brother-in-law, who roofs for a living and does not have a website either.

Anytime: the homeowner

The burst pipe does not care about any of this. What she meets is a clean page that loads instantly, a name that matches the truck outside, three real reviews, and a button her thumb can find without reading. Help is booked in under a minute. Three people, one machine, and everybody comes out ahead before dinner.

11. Risks and Honest Caveats

Every plan read by family deserves a straight-faced risk section. The big one is rejection volume: for a while, most people will say no or say nothing at all, and that is priced in rather than suffered. The rhythm is built on volume; a hundred touches containing three yeses is a working machine, not a failure. Expect quiet weeks in the middle; the calendar is the antidote, not the mood.

- Machine-written words can occasionally be off-key. Every site gets a human read before it goes live, and the factory flags anything it is unsure about rather than guessing.
- The laptop is the factory floor. Daily habits keep it alive, and a full backup copies to a cheap external drive every week, so a stolen machine costs a day, not the business.
- Free tools can change their terms. The design uses interchangeable parts behind one standard connection, so a swapped provider is an evening of adjustment, not a rebuild. Every account stays in the operator's own name.
- Income is lumpy, not a salary. Three small payments in six weeks is the promise; the plan does not pretend to be a paycheck, and living costs should not be stacked on top of it in month one.
- Enthusiasm fades on hard weeks. The system is built as daily checkboxes with a minimum viable day of three touches, so momentum survives even the rough stretches.

What would kill this outright: sending nothing. Every other failure on the list above has a patch attached. The one failure with no patch is silence, which is why the whole design bends toward making the daily ten as easy as pressing a button.

12. After the First $2,000

The forty-five-day plan ends with money in the account and, more valuably, three live storefronts on the internet carrying the Charm City Sites signature at the bottom of each page. The second act is mostly repetition with variation: point the same factory at electricians, then heating-and-cooling shops, one trade at a time, reusing every lesson the spreadsheet has recorded about what makes a owner say yes.

Two quiet upgrades follow naturally. A small monthly care plan, offered only to clients who ask, covers tiny edits and keeps phone numbers current; even a handful of these turns lumpy income steadier. The missed-call helper grows into a fuller assistant that books jobs and answers common questions after hours, which trade owners pay for gladly because it works while they sleep.

Month three, in one sentence: a handful of trade businesses whose phones ring more, a growing wall of local testimonials, and a machine that makes each new yes cheaper to earn than the last. Growth, if it comes, arrives because demand pulls it, not because the operator pushes.

13. Where This Came From

Document	Charm City Sites: A One-Person Website Factory for Baltimore's Trades
Date written	September 28, 2026
Source	zai-web conversation (bookmark it in the browser to reopen it without searching)
Session ID	web-e15a3a9a-9a75-4e64-b32c-a8d954bad4bf
Chat ID	478466ed-b8b6-467c-9097-f991c4dba44c
Login email	_____ (write it in; only visible on the account holder's side)

This plan was drafted with an AI assistant across one working session that covered market research, tool verification, and system design. The identifiers above exist so the source conversation can be found again without digging through twenty accounts; bookmarking the chat in the browser is the fastest route back, and this document is the durable record either way. It is meant to be shared freely with anyone the operator chooses to trust with it.